



cover story GUJARAT ELECTIONS

BETWEEN THEM, THE CONGRESS AND BJP LACK HOMEGROWN LEADERSHIP IN TWO-THIRDS

BIHAR



NITISH KUMAR JD(U)
LALU YADAV RJD



BJP
CONGRESS

The Congress, which has been out of power for long, and BJP, have no leader to match Lalu or Nitish Kumar.

WEST BENGAL



M. BANERJEE TC
BUDDHADEB CPI(M)



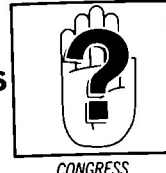
BJP
CONGRESS

Neither the Congress nor BJP has any leaders to match the crowdpull of Mamata Banerjee or Buddhadeb.

GUJARAT



NARENDRA MODI BJP



CONGRESS

Mauled once again by Moditva, the Congress has time on its hands as it prepares to fight again five years hence.

CHHATTISGARH



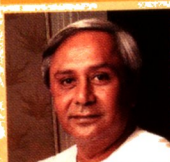
RAMAN SINGH BJP



AJIT JOGI CONGRESS

In the near-two-party set-up that exists in the state, poli fervour could deliver the mandate to either side.

ORISSA



NAVEEN PATNAIK BJD



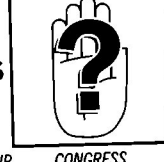
CONGRESS

The Congress doesn't have a leader to take on Naveen and BJP seems content playing second fiddle to BJD.

KARNATAKA



B.S. YEDIYURAPPA BJP
H.D. KUMARASWAMY JD(S)



CONGRESS

BJP and JD(S) fall out, kiss-and-make-up and then fall out, but there is no Congress leader to capitalise.

UTTAR PRADESH



MAYAWATI BSP
MULAYAM SP



BJP
CONGRESS

The regional leaders have now acquired national stature, but the two parties are facing a leadership drought in the state.

TAMIL NADU



KARUNANIDHI DMK
JAYALALITHAA AIADMK



BJP
CONGRESS

A switch of partners in 2004 changed the government at the Centre. Both the Congress and BJP can at best be good allies.

MADHYA PRADESH



S.S. CHAUHAN BJP



CONGRESS

The Congress's most formidable vote-catcher has been moved out, leaving the field open for BJP.

hysteria. It was the Leader as the liberator. Annadurai made maximum political capital out of Dravidian exceptionalism. MGR added filmi kitsch to it and the cult of dark glasses and fur cap was born. Later, in the neighbouring Andhra Pradesh, NTR would repeat the same theology of regional salvation with silver screen perfection. They made politics a spectacle of mythological proportion. They were the pioneers of the rath yatra. J. Jayalalthaa and M. Karunanidhi carry the tradition forward. Their mass base remains intact.

Does the Congress or BJP have such leaders in any state? Neither of the

national parties has a leader with a pan-Indian or even state-wide appeal. Such a reality is all the more debilitating at a time when, even by the most charitable accounts, the Advani-Rajnath combination in BJP and the Sonia-Manmohan Singh partnership in the Congress can't win more than 160 seats for their respective parties. It is in this context that the Modi magnetism becomes something rare—and politically necessary. In Gujarat, he was the only leader whose modest rally was attended by over 20,000 people. On December 16, when he turned up to cast his vote, a 10,000-strong crowd was waiting for a glimpse of the Leader.

Mayawati is not far behind. She is a crowd-puller even beyond Uttar Pradesh. Her rally last month was the largest in Mumbai in recent times. In Gujarat, too, she was a huge hit, though her party didn't win any seat there. In communist West Bengal, Mamata Banerjee is a bigger crowd-puller than Sonia or any other Congress leader. Something must have gone terribly wrong in the Congress. The most experienced party in power today doesn't have a single leader who can attract a crowd of more than 5,000.

So pathetic is the credibility of some national leaders that even the candidates find excuses to discourage them